



Ready to enthrall: (left to right) **1.** Germany's Julian Weber is the world leader in javelin throw at 91.51m. **2.** Parul Chaudhary met the automatic qualification mark for the Worlds with a new national record of 9:12.46s. **3.** Norway's Karsten Warholm, who shattered the 46-second barrier in the Tokyo Olympic 400m hurdles final, will reunite with USA's Rai Benjamin and Brazil's Alison dos Santos for another epic showdown. REUTERS, GETTY IMAGES and AFP

Along with Neeraj, three more Indians — Sachin Yadav, Yash Vir Singh and Rohit Yadav — will compete in the men's javelin throw in Tokyo. None of the three could achieve the automatic qualifying mark of 85.50m for Tokyo — Sachin came close with his silver-winning throw of 85.16m at the Asian Championships — and had to rely on the world rankings route. But the presence of four Indians in a 36-man field is proof of the country's increasing depth in the discipline.

In the women's javelin event, national record holder Annu Rani will make her fifth appearance at the World Championships. Her season's best is 62.59m but she might need more to better her seventh-place finish from Oregon 2022.

Another interesting storyline to follow is what lies ahead in long jumper Murali Sreeshankar's inspired comeback story — returning from a year-long absence due to a serious knee injury to make a late charge and qualify for the World Championships.

Triple jumper Praveen Chithravel enters the event with a season's best of 17.37m, the eighth-best jump in the world this year. Abdulla Aboobacker will be the other Indian

triple jumper in the 36-strong field.

On the track, the major Indians in focus will be middle-distance runner Gulveer Singh, steeplechaser Parul Chaudhary, and sprinter Animesh Kujur.

Gulveer, who set new national records in the 5000m and 10,000m this year, is set to compete in both events. The army man has impressed with consistent performances, showing steady improvement throughout the season.

Parul hasn't raced since she finished second at the Asian Championships in May, where she met the automatic qualification mark for the Worlds with a new national record of 9:12.46s. While a podium finish in Tokyo is unrealistic, her target will be to better her own personal best (NR).

Animesh is set to become the first-ever Indian male sprinter to compete at the World Championships after qualifying for the 200m through the rankings. For the 22-year-old, it will be an invaluable experience to race alongside world champion Noah Lyles, Olympic champion Letsile Tebogo, and Australian teen sensation Gout Gout. The country's

squad could have been bigger had steeplechaser Avinash Sable, heptathlete Nandini Agasara, and race walker Akshdeep Singh not been ruled out for medical reasons.

The failure of the relay squads to book a spot for the worlds is another reason behind the slightly reduced strength compared to Budapest 2023, where the men's 4x400m quartet secured a stunning fifth-place finish.

Among the international stars, the biggest name to keep an eye on is Swedish pole vaulter Armand 'Mondo' Duplantis. Mondo has broken the world record 13 times and there is every reason to believe he can clear the bar set at 6.30m to take the tally to 14.

Lyles and Jamaican Kishane Thompson will renew their rivalry for the men's 100m title. In the women's 100m, Julien Alfred would love a repeat of her Paris Olympics upset of Sha'Carri Richardson. For 'Pocket Rocket' Shelly-Ann Fraser-Pryce, it will be an emotional occasion, as the five-time world champion from Jamaica has announced that she will retire after the event.

The Tokyo Olympics produced the greatest men's 400m hurdles race in history, with Norway's Karsten